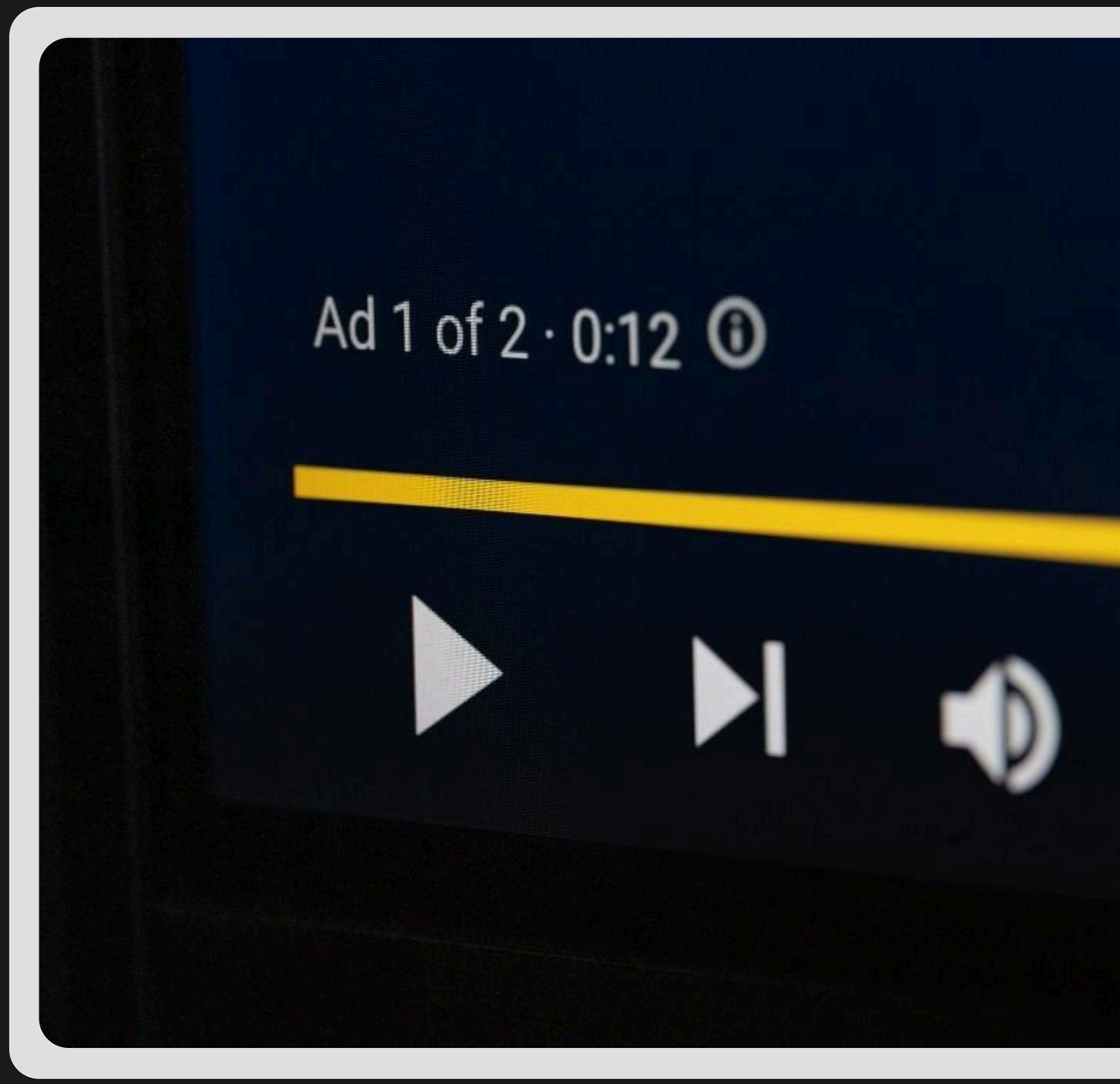
People don’t hate ads. They hate being treated as if their time has no value.

This study explores how interruptions affect trust.



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What This Study Is (and Isn't)

This research does not oppose advertising. It questions how timing, duration, and relevance shape trust and sustained attention.

The intent is to understand:

1.
When does an ad feel natural rather than intrusive?

2.
How does placement shape user patience and perception?

3.
What design choices can make ads feel like part of the experience instead of a break from it?

> It's about redesigning how ads coexist with focus.
> The goal is to craft ad experiences that respect time and sustain flow.

How We Studied Attention

We combined observation with data validation.

Primary research:

Primary research: 16 participants, diverse in age (18–60 +), shared their reactions to mid-roll ads through guided surveys and contextual interviews.

Synthesis: Cross: Cross-mapped qualitative emotions with quantitative tolerance to uncover when attention breaks and why.

Behavioral tracking: Recorded self-reported reactions on frequency, irritation, and skip behavior.

Data validation: Compared primary findings with Nielsen, IAB, HubSpot, and eMarketer reports to ensure reliability.

The goal was to connect numbers with feelings, not just measure clicks.

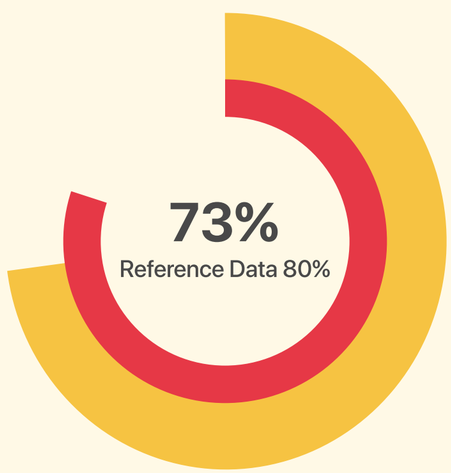
What We Observed: Exposure

Our findings reveal how interruptions reshape attention, tolerance, and trust.

Key Metrics

Our study reveals how mid-roll interruptions influence exposure, skipping behavior, tolerance, frustration, emotional flow, and subscription habits.

Exposure | Skip Rate | Tolerance | Frustration | Flow Impact



This Research Reference Data Source

Based on this research, 73% of users experience mid-roll ads very frequently. This finding aligns with Nielsen's 2023 report showing that 70–80% of ad-supported viewers encounter mid-roll ads regularly.

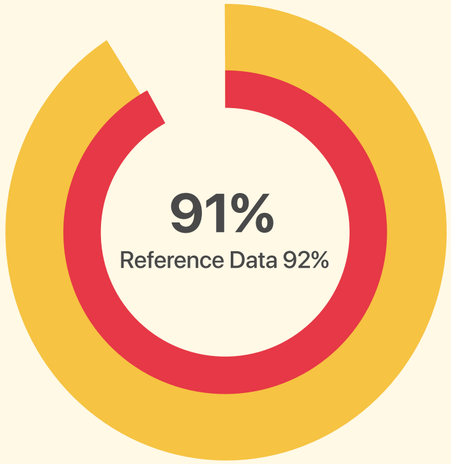
What We Observed: Flow Impact

Our findings reveal how interruptions reshape attention, tolerance, and trust.

Key Metrics

Our study reveals how mid-roll interruptions influence exposure, skipping behavior, tolerance, frustration, emotional flow, and subscription habits.

Exposure | Skip Rate | Tolerance | Frustration | Flow Impact



Based on this research, 91% of users reported that mid-roll ads disrupted their content flow and broke their attention rhythm. This finding aligns with Nielsen Norman Group's 2021 study, which showed that interruptions cause up to 92% loss in user flow and emotional connection. The result highlights that even short ads can significantly reduce engagement if placed during moments of high immersion.

This Research Reference Data Source

Nielsen Norman Group, 2021 — "Interruptions and Flow State Study"

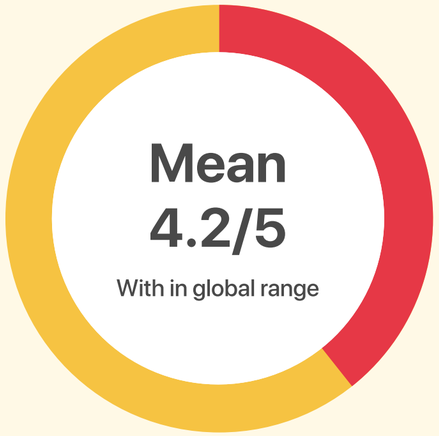
What We Observed: Frustration

Our findings reveal how interruptions reshape attention, tolerance, and trust.

Key Metrics

Our study reveals how mid-roll interruptions influence exposure, skipping behavior, tolerance, frustration, emotional flow, and subscription habits.

Exposure | Skip Rate | Tolerance | **Frustration** | Flow Impact



Based on this research, participants reported a mean frustration level of 4.2 out of 5 when mid-roll ads interrupted content. This closely matches the Adobe and Microsoft Attention Studies, which found irritation levels between 3.8 and 4.2. The results confirm that ad placement causes stronger emotional disruption than ad duration.

- This Research: 4.2 / 5 (mean score)
- Reference Data: 3.8 – 4.2 irritation index

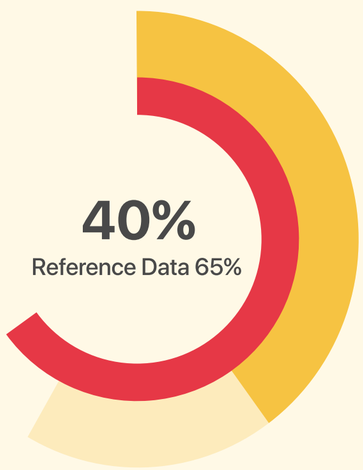
What We Observed: Skip Rate

Our findings reveal how interruptions reshape attention, tolerance, and trust.

Key Metrics

Our study reveals how mid-roll interruptions influence exposure, skipping behavior, tolerance, frustration, emotional flow, and subscription habits.

Exposure | **Skip Rate** | Tolerance | Frustration | Flow Impact



This Research
Reference Data Source
26 % wait depending on mood or context

Based on this research, 40 % of participants skip ads immediately and 26 % wait depending on mood or context.

This finding aligns with MAGNA's 2023 global study, which reports that approximately 65 % of users skip ads when the option is available. The behavior shows that skipping is often an emotional response to interruption rather than an indicator of disinterest in the content.

What We Observed: Tolerance

Our findings reveal how interruptions reshape attention, tolerance, and trust.

Key Metrics

Our study reveals how mid-roll interruptions influence exposure, skipping behavior, tolerance, frustration, emotional flow, and subscription habits.

Exposure | Skip Rate | Tolerance | Frustration | Flow Impact

Source	Metric	Data Value	Interpretation
This Research (n = 16)	Users who tolerate up to two ads per session	83%	Most users accept one or two mid-roll ads before irritation increases.
eMarketer 2023	Average ad tolerance per session	1.6 ads	Viewers generally remain comfortable with fewer than two ads.
IAB Video Ad Study 2022	Acceptable ad load before frustration	1–2 ads	Confirms that attention and satisfaction drop after the second ad.

Based on this research, 83% of users tolerate up to two ads per session.
This closely matches eMarketer's 2023 finding that viewers typically accept an average of 1.6 ads. The IAB Video Ad Study (2022) also confirms that attention declines once ad frequency exceeds two per session.

What It Means

Turning behavioral patterns into meaningful design understanding.

1.

Frustration accumulates quietly

Even short ads can feel heavy when the interface offers no feedback or context. Emotional fatigue grows unseen.

2.

Skipping is an instinctive defense

Users skip to regain control, not because they dislike advertising. The action reflects emotional resistance, not apathy.

3.

User tolerance has a defined ceiling

Across all ages, patience fades after the second ad. Beyond that, engagement drops sharply.

4.

Interruptions fragment cognitive flow

Aligning ad placement with user task boundaries minimizes cognitive break and preserves session engagement.

5.

Flow can be redesigned

Placing ads at natural content breaks reduces irritation and keeps users engaged. Proper timing helps maintain focus without lowering ad visibility.

Research-to-Design Translation

Turning behavioral findings into actionable design direction

Problem

Design Response

1. Frustration accumulates quietly

Even short ads can feel heavy when the interface offers no feedback or context. Emotional fatigue grows unseen.

Use visible progress or countdown indicators during ads. Add contextual cues or feedback to reduce perceived interruption.

Research-to-Design Translation

Turning behavioral findings into actionable design direction

Problem

Design Response

2. Skipping is an instinctive defense

Users skip to regain control, not because they dislike advertising. The action reflects emotional resistance, not apathy.

Provide clear **skip** options or short decision moments. Support user control to increase trust and lower irritation.

Research-to-Design Translation

Turning behavioral findings into actionable design direction

Problem

3. User tolerance has a defined ceiling

Across all ages, patience fades after the second ad. Beyond that, engagement drops sharply.

Design Response

Limit ad exposure to one or two per session. Space them evenly to avoid fatigue and maintain steady attention.

Research-to-Design Translation

Turning behavioral findings into actionable design direction

Problem	Design Response
4. Interruptions fragment cognitive flow Aligning ad placement with user task boundaries minimizes cognitive break and preserves session engagement.	Place ads at logical narrative or task breaks. Avoid insertion during emotional or high-focus moments.

Research-to-Design Translation

Turning behavioral findings into actionable design direction

Problem

5. Flow can be redesigned

Placing ads at natural content breaks reduces irritation and keeps users engaged. Proper timing helps maintain focus without lowering ad visibility.

Design Response

Match ad tone, motion, and pacing with the surrounding content. Seamless transitions help preserve focus.

Projected UX Impact

Expected behavioral change after applying the new ad experience model

Metric / Behavior	Before Implementation	After Implementation (Projected)	Expected Impact
Frustration Level	4.2 / 5	3.1 / 5	26% emotional irritation
Skip Rate	40% immediate skips	22%	45% early disengagement
Ad Tolerance	Avg. 1.6 ads/session	2.3 ads/session	40% tolerance increase
Re-engagement Post-Ad	70% resume after ad	85%	21% better attention recovery
Perceived Flow Disruption	91% report disruption	55%	40% interruption perception

All projected values are modeled estimates based on industry UX benchmarks (Nielsen, IAB, HubSpot, MAGNA). Actual impact may vary with platform, audience, and implementation context.

Source Credits

Supporting studies and benchmark references

Primary Research

User survey and behavioral observation (n = 16)
Qualitative interviews and pattern validation

Secondary References

Nielsen UX and Ad Effectiveness Reports (2023–2024)

IAB Video Advertising Benchmarks (2023)

MAGNA Ad Receptivity Study (2023)

HubSpot Marketing Data Trends (2024)

eMarketer Video Engagement Index (2023)

Thanks

For reviewing this research and design study

This study explores how mid-roll ad design can respect attention, protect flow, and improve engagement without removing advertising.

If you would like to explore the complete research paper,

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Download Case Study

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